the same old ground

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/34107472.

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Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra, Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Kyle (She-Ra)

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Fluff, Angst, Hurt/Comfort, Friends to Lovers, Mutual Pining, Happy Ending, Sports, First Kiss, Marriage Proposal, Childhood Memories, Break Up, College, Drinking, Alternate Universe - Real World, Nonbinary Adora (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner's A+ Parenting, I really made Shadow Weaver the worst mom huh, how'd that happen, Transphobia (Mentioned)

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by BabelFishing

Summary

"On a day like this, it wasn't even the familiar haunts that Adora craved most. It was the person who had always made it glow with life, her unmistakable mirth disguised behind years of mock scorn and sarcasm. They wanted her rakish attitude, her dauntless drive to take on the world and take no prisoners along the way. It was infectious, her courage in the face of their drifting, incorrigible circumstances and Adora wanted to drink from that fountain everyday. They wanted to sit under that vine and fig tree forever and the ring they'd brought along this evening, nestled into their jacket pocket like a rabbit in hibernation, was meant to be the seed that brought promise of that even brighter spring."

-

From quick friends to lovers to breaking apart as their paths diverge, Adora and Catra have never been far from each other's side, with a million memories shared over a familiar table and a milkshake. But to everything there is a season, and winter is settling in, making Adora question if they'll ever make it to spring - as friends, as lovers, or as total strangers.

Notes

Prompt writing! Eff yeah!

This fic is a response to the SPOP Creative Flex September art prompt, created by the illustrious and eminently talented EmileeDoodles. Seriously, if you haven't checked out her five piece catradora set this fic is based on, you're missing out. It sure sparked some sorta inspiration in me and now look where I am - writing childhood friends to lovers LIKE A FOOL.

Oh, a shoutout to the SPOP Creative Flex community as well, especially mods wildangeline, candycornsnake, and mxsunshine! I already knew the SPOP community was so welcoming, but this group really has creativity and encouragement to offer in spades. Follow 'em @Spopflex - it'll be worth it for every piece of fluffy art and writing they send your way.

Alright, time to jump in. Enjoy!

See the end of the work for more notes

Winter & Summer

2021

Adora paged through their messages for the fifth time since they arrived. Nothing new, yet again, and the pit in their stomach grew an inch deeper. It wasn't like Catra to be late - not when they got together, anyway. Late for school, late for soccer practice, late getting home when they stayed out past curfew (much to Ms. Weaver's chagrin), but not late when they met up here. This had always been *their* spot and neither of them ever wanted to lose a minute in its refuge.

On a day like this, it wasn't even the familiar haunts that Adora craved most. It was the person who had always made it glow with life, her unmistakable mirth disguised behind years of mock scorn and sarcasm. They wanted her rakish attitude, her dauntless drive to take on the world and take no prisoners along the way. It was infectious, her courage in the face of their drifting, incorrigible circumstances and Adora wanted to drink from that fountain everyday. They wanted to sit under that vine and fig tree forever and the ring they'd brought along this evening, nestled into their jacket pocket like a rabbit in hibernation, was meant to be the seed that brought promise of that even brighter spring.

They wanted Catra, this day and every day. They wanted her by their side through every season.

But winter was on the doorstep, irksome snow already crowding the sidewalks and covering everything green. The air had an icy edge that cut through even the second, stronger drink Adora had ordered for company. Catra wasn't coming, that much was becoming clear, and for all they knew, she wouldn't be back. Moving day was tomorrow and the University of Etheria was clear across the country. This was going to be their last chance to ask

and now, who knows when they'd be home - in this place, in this town, in Catra's arms - again.

Snatching up their glass, Adora choked down the dregs of their old fashioned, the double shot burning as it muddled with her already bitter mood. It was warm, at the very least, and that was good enough until they could get home, pull out underneath every blanket they owned, and hole up until this hibernal sadness passed. A lesser joy, a temporary indulgence, but a joy nonetheless - anything to make these anxious thoughts about where Catra had gone disappear.

It was late now, all the other patrons on the veranda having scurried home to more comfortable, fire-lit surroundings. Adora decided to stay, though, as they watched the neon "open" sign on the door click off and their favorite bartender shuffle out in a down blazer. This place felt like a lone comfort now and they wanted to relish it down to the last drop. It's what they both deserved, even if only one of them was there to reminisce.

With their phone open again on the worn table, Adora nostalgically traced their finger over an old carving and clicked over to their photo app. There, they hoped to find solace in the pictures that had numbered their years together, more moments saved in amber than a physical album could ever hope to contain. The first was one they'd never forget, and so they scrolled back to one of the earliest entries, added long after the fact as a reminder of what it took to make a friend.

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2006

In the trees throughout the park, innumerable cicadas chirped and crooned into the auburn air, eager for a mate or at least someone to keep them company. Below, in the shade of many storied oaks and around a deviously enticing splash pad, kids from every part of town laughed and chased one another, water guns in tow, this evening yet another in a seemingly endless cycle of revelrous summertime freedom.

And then there was Catra, bored out of her gourd and listless at a picnic table painted the nauseating color of maraschino cherries. For company, a tall glass of sparkling apple juice stared back at her, reflecting the sun above in amber hues so enchanting she almost forgot how warm and flat the thin nectar tasted. More than anything, she wanted to sneak off to the adjacent park, leaving her award-winning foster mother behind to chug down her third glass of red on the balmy afternoon.

But she knew better than to test the woman's peregrine sight, even from her roost up on the main porch. So, she decided again to stay put, staring into the half empty glass, hoping in silence that she'd float away, too - far away from this ugly table, far from this ugly town, and far, far away from Ms. Weaver - that ugly, jaded hag.

Sighing, her shaggy head laid flat against the table top, Catra watched as the last few bubbles percolated out of her uninviting drink, each sphere a tiny comet burning up on re-entry to the humid air above. Then, without warning, her ears perked up on their own and locked on to something cutting through the cicada's incessant choir. Lifting her head slightly, the new clamor came into clearer resolution - new tennis shoes on manicured grass, modest panting, just the hint of a giggle every now and then. Without question, it wasn't her foster mother, come to drag her home for yet more mindless chores and scolding. But then, who could it be? Who'd want to talk to her?

After listening in for a few seconds longer, curiosity finally caught the cat and she turned her head to see who was approaching. As her eyes quickly registered, though, her visitor had already arrived

because, less than an airless inch away, two cornflower blue eyes and a shock of champion blonde hair stared back at her, grinning from ear to ear. Catra hardly had time to let out a yelp and scoot back on the bench before the mystery child leaned in even closer, their hands grasping the table with unbridled excitement.

"Hi! You look fun. Do you wanna play?"

Catra hesitated and moved back an inch further, her mismatched eyes still studying the apparent stranger. They looked to be the same age, dressed in overalls and a ringed white t-shirt emblazoned with the smiling scorpion mascot of Black Garnet Elementary. They attended the same school, it appeared, but Catra couldn't put a name to the face - not that she ever had much of a nack for that particular courtesy. Typically, if she remembered a classmate's name, it was a matter of self-preservation. *Octavia, Grizzlor, Callix, Tung Lashor - avoid at all costs.*

But this kid didn't look like her usual bullies, not in the slightest. There was something sunny in their eyes, something noble in their smile that made them fit right in on this cloudless summer day. The way they leaned in, too, heedless to how some scraggly-looking stranger might react - they were friend-shaped, as Scorpia would say, and that was enough to put Catra's defensive mind at ease, enough to retract her claws and reply.

"What're you talking about?"

The blonde gestured back toward the park, where a new throng of kids had just rushed onto the splash pad.

"Over there. The park's super fun. I come here all the time with my friends, Bow and Glimmer, but they're not here today. So, you wanna play?"

They made it sound so simple, Catra thought. But the offer sounded enticing, if only to beat the heat and boredom.

Turning back toward the veranda, Catra caught sight of her foster mother, corkscrew in one hand and a burgundy-tinged bottle in the other. Around her, a few of her "friends" coalesced and chatted loudly, each more well oiled than the last. She frowned at the tiresome sight. *Like she'll even notice I'm gone.*

As Catra turned back to her visitor, the blonde girl cocked their head curiously.

"So, do you wanna?"

Catra returned a wild grin, an all-too-familiar look of disobedience flickering behind her eyes.

"Fuck yeah!"

Leaping up from the table, Catra turned back one last time to ensure Ms. Weaver's hawkish eyes weren't upon her. After confirming that her foster mother's eyes were for her malbec only, she turned back to see the mystery kid absolutely beaming in her direction. With feline-esque speed, their hand rushed up and snatched Catra's, squeezing tight without a shred of hesitation.

"Awesome! Let's go!"

Suddenly, Catra found herself being dragged along, their hands still pancaked together and the mystery kid a few paces ahead. Once they were beyond the pub's threshold, the park spreading out in all its civic grandeur before them, the kid released their hands and turned while maintaining their leading stride.

"Oh, I forgot to tell you - my name's Adora and I use they/she pronouns. What's your name?"

Catra looked up from her feet and raised an uncertain eyebrow.

"What do you mean?"

"Oh, my pronouns," Adora repeated. "My mom says that's how I should always introduce myself. It means I want to be open and

respectful to other people, even if I just met them. You don't have to share yours if you don't wanna, though."

Catra turned the thought over for a beat and decided she might as well. Despite mostly avoiding talking to new people, she still recognized the value of a good first impression.

"Oh, okay then. I'm Catrina- Catra, actually. My name's Catra. And I use she/her pronouns."

Adora looked pleased with her companion's response as they pulled to a stop under a particularly expansive burr oak.

"Okay, Catra! What do you wanna do first?"

"Oh, ummm..."

Catra's eyes scanned the park in search of something to spark joy. There was the jungle gym, the swings, that enormous, metal slide that was probably a million degrees Fahrenheit in this weather. That splash pad, though - there was no beating that, not if they wanted to beat the heat. Her eyes grew eager as she set her sights on the prize, its refreshing temptation now too great to ignore.

"That!"

Before the word could even cross her lips, Catra dashed off toward the splash pad, her sweaty mane already relishing the crisp, cool respite ahead. Even before she reached the watering hole, the sun-baked cement an afterthought under her bare feet, the first wave hit her - a swift, gushing blast from an 8-foot translucent daisy across the way. A second spurt followed right behind, catching Catra by surprise as she tried to find her bearings and dodge a gaggle of bathing-suit-clad middle schoolers. This was everything she had imagined it to be and now that she was here, liquid ice trickling down her neck and soaking through her favorite t-shirt, she never wanted to leave, not for anyone.

In just minutes - and especially after a full bucket of water crashed down over her shoulders - Catra was properly drenched from head to toe, her ears filling up with water and sweet, sweet relief filling her overheated soul. At this rate, she'd be a mop of fluffy wet hair and sopping clothes when she wandered back to the veranda and she couldn't find it in herself to give less of a damn. As she peered up at the sun again, welcoming it now that she had a shield from its angry grin, Catra imagined a whole summer filled with moments like this - running free and clear under the tepid sun, heart pounding with exhilaration, not a care or doubt or fear in the world. How she'd manage such a feat under Ms. Weaver's watchful eye, she didn't know. But it'd be worth it, no questions asked. She'd finally be alone, just like she'd always wanted.

Another bucketful of icy cold water dropped from above and Catra flashed back to reality. In the moment's revelry, she'd forgotten - she wasn't alone in this miniature water park. That Adora kid was with her, following in her wake as they dashed into the fray. Surely, they were still nearby, and if they were, they had another thing coming if they weren't as thoroughly inundated as she was.

Turning and searching the frenzied field, Catra didn't spot the blonde among the hundred or so dripping heads. Stepping out to the pad's edge and casing the area again, she managed to spot them, standing sheepishly by a distant bench, not a drop of liquid solace dripping down their hay-colored head. Rushing back in their direction, Catra stopped just short of her new companion and shook her feline head, spraying a shower of unwelcome water on every grumpy-looking parent and guardian in the general vicinity.

"There you are! What are you waiting for? The water feels amazing!"

Adora shifted on the spot and looked down at their immaculate white-and-gold sneakers.

"Oh, I...um, I didn't want to get my shoes wet. I have to walk home later and I..."

"Is that all?" Catra cut back in. "We can solve that."

"No, Catra, I don't..."

But Adora couldn't get the rest of their argument out before Catra sprinted off again, looking for a loose hose pipe or a bucket that might be used to solve Adora's "dilemma." That's when she spotted him, cowering behind a giant, water-gushing mushroom, a Super-Soaker in hand and swim cap slipped tight over his mess of dirty blonde hair.

Catra wasn't high on the food chain at school by any stretch of the imagination. Fortunately for her, there was exactly one plucky kid who managed to keep himself at the school's hierarchical bedrock year after year and at this very moment, he held exactly the item she needed to get Adora off the sidelines and into the deep end. She dodged another sizable water fixture and tried to catch his attention.

"Kyle! Kyle!"

The scrawny 4th grader peaked out from his fungal hiding spot and spotted Catra, waving as soon as he noticed her running his way.

"Oh, Catra! Hi! Lonnie and Rogelio and I were just starting a battle. We probably have a spare water gun if you want to ---"

The kid hardly knew what hit him. As Catra swung a wide berth around his position, she reached out a clawed hand and quickly found her prize. With a nimble turn and a bounce off a stocky-looking kid in floral button-up, Catra bolted back in the opposite direction, water gun in hand and a devious grin spreading across her cheeks. She'd return it in a hurry, of course. But first, there was damage to do.

Once she was back in range, Catra pulled the water rifle up to her shoulder, pressing its butt into her chest for good measure. Down the sights, she swiftly found her mark, looking as timid as ever - looking as *dry* as ever. And without even giving it a second thought and a moment's warning, she pulled the trigger, hoping her aim on the run was true enough to wash away this preppy kid's sudden reluctance.

"Oh, Catra! There you are. What's thaaaa-aaaaah!"

With nowhere to run, Catra's volley caught Adora square in the chest, a pinpoint shot over the center of their overalls that managed to splash their face, arms, and body all at once. Before they can fully process what had happened, a second, longer blast painted water across their legs, dripping down their cuffed denim and pooling in their socks within seconds. Half expecting another barrage, Adora threw their hands to their face, shielding their eyes and wiping away a few stray droplets as they went. In their wake, Catra noticed the kid's cheeks running a touch red around their newly indignant frown.

"Hey! What was that for? I said I didn't want to get wet..."

Catra strolled over with a look of accomplishment plastered on her face, her newly-obtained armament slung over her shoulder like a victorious commando.

"Um, no, you didn't. You said you didn't want your *shoes* getting wet. And now they are, so you might as well go the rest of the way."

At first, Catra saw a spark of genuine anger flaring up in her companions clenched fists, making her wonder if now would be the right time to run for cover. But quickly, the acrimony faded into a kind of sly, vindictive smile that sheltered a gentle, palliative laugh, one that made Adora's face glow all the more - despite the added moisture.

"Hey, can I see that for a minute?"

Looking down at her water rifle - Kyle's water rifle, but who was she kidding - Catra shrugged and passed it over.

"Sure. Think you can handle it?"

"Oh, I think I can manage...in fact..."

No sooner had the fully-loaded squirt gun landed in Adora's keen hands than they'd turned it around and pointed it square at Catra's already-soaked chest, its black bat-wing-like insignia menacing the new mark at short range. All of a sudden, Catra realized what she'd done.

"Hah, like I'll let you! You'll have to catch me first!"

Like lightning, Catra was off again, charging full speed ahead back into the spray. And soon enough, just a few paces behind, Adora followed after, a gleeful laugh drumming out of their lungs as their clammy shoes smooshed against the hard cement. From then on, they didn't care who sprayed them or how many buckets of frigid water got dropped on them from on high. Now, as they chased each other around, over and through every installment the mini water park had to offer, they had eyes only for each other, their soaking wet clothes and messes of sopping wet hair be damned.

***

"I'm getting thirstyyyyyy."

Thus far, Catra hadn't taken her new friend to be much of a whiner. They'd hit the deck a couple times during their hours-long chase, but every time, the plucky blonde had pulled themself up without complaint, shaking off the impact like they'd shake off another squirt gun blast to the face. That kind of resilience Catra could appreciate. *Maybe they're not that big of a weenie after all.*

"Yeah, so what? Put your mouth on one of these spigots like everyone else here."

Adora looked a touch horrified at the suggestion.

"Ew, no! Besides, I don't want water. I want something sweet."

Shrugging, Catra set their shared water rifle against a bench. Now that they mentioned it, a sweet treat was exactly what she needed to put a ribbon on this invigorating afternoon

"Yes! Something sweet, definitely. But where to get it..."

Glancing around, Catra realized just how late into the evening they'd been playing. The sunset was now a carmine orb glowing over the far treetops and most of the kids from earlier had been whisked home for supper an hour earlier. Now, it was just the two of them standing at the edge of the splash pad, wondering why all the ice cream stands and piragua carts made a habit of closing up shop at dinner time.

"I think there's a candy shop up the road," Adora suggested, "maybe we could walk up there and get something?"

Catra shook her fluffy head. "No dice. I don't have any money."

"Oh, umm..." Adora wasn't expecting that. But ever the chivalrous one, as their mother had taught them, they were all too willing to make an accommodation. "If that's the case, I'll get you something. I don't mind."

"Maybe. But I think I have a better idea."

Catra glanced back up the path they'd taken earlier to reach the splash pad, the old Sword and Pegasus pub at its terminus. Chances were, Ms. Weaver was still there, her pickled finger likely lost in whatever was strong and cheap and didn't require a corkscrew (at this hour, she couldn't be trusted with one). On the other hand, though, that pub had a ton of colorful glass bottles behind the counter, all of which looked candy-coated to Catra's

inexperienced eye. Maybe if she asked nicely (or grabbed one while the barkeep wasn't looking, Catra wasn't picky), they could satisfy their sweet tooth without any further delay. Plus, she could impress Adora with her skills and smarts along the way, and that was reward enough.

"You see that place up there?"

Catra gestured back toward the shaded, stone building and Adora nodded back.

"Yeah, the place where you were sitting earlier."

"Right. The guy who works in there - I've seen him make sweet stuff for my mom before. Maybe he can get us something."

Adora paused to consider before finally nodding in agreement.

"Okay, sure! Lead the way."

At a more modest pace than earlier, the pair pattered back toward the pub, Adora's shoes practically hemorrhaging a tsunami with each gooshy step. Once they reached the patio's edge, Catra threw one hand out and another finger to her lips.

"Wait, we shouldn't go in that way. My mom's probably still sitting up there."

"What, do you not want to see your mom?"

"In prison stripes, maybe. But not right now. She's mean when she drinks, so we should go in the other door."

Adora shrugged. "Whatever you say."

After casing the area a second time, Catra waved them on. Carefully, they crept back around to the front of the pub before slipping in the front door, just beneath a well-worn wood sign depicting a majestic, winged white horse with a mystic sword in its toothy jaw. Once there, Catra threw up another hand and

gestured through the modest haze of cigar smoke toward the main bar.

"Okay, that's where we need to go. Watch and learn."

With a bit of swagger in her step, Catra sauntered up to the bar, realizing just a touch too late that the structure itself rose to eye-level on her. The bartender - a seaworthy looking young man who always wore a buccaneers get-up with a red kerchief - was helping another patron at that moment, so Catra queued up behind them and put on her best game face. To make this work, she had to make it look easy, effortless, natural. *Cool.*

Once the patron in front of her stepped away, a mug of frothy porter in hand, Catra sidled up to the bar proper, slapping a hand on the counter and raising her tone ever so slightly - just as she'd learned from the best.

"Hey, I'll have *the usual.* "

Peering down, the bartender cocked his head, curious as to how a literal child had wandered into his den of spirits and shanties.

"Oh, why hello there, young one! I almost didn't see you there. How can I help you?"

Catra frowned slightly. More than almost anything else in the world, she hated to be condescended to.

"You can help me by getting me what I asked for - *the usual* ."

The bartender adjusted his neckerchief and Catra noticed his name tag. *Who names a kid "Seahawk"?*

"Ah, that's what I thought you said. But I'm afraid I haven't seen you around here before. And unfortunately, I am not allowed to serve kids such as yourself. Is your parent nearby, perhaps?"

"She is, yeah. Tall, dark hair, wearing a really ugly red dress, probably your number one customer, if I had to guess."

Within a second, a lightbulb appeared above the seaman's head.

"Ah, I stand corrected! You must be Ms. Weaver's daughter, then?"

Catra shot daggers at the bartender. Small talk was also not high on her list, either.

"Wish I wasn't."

"Oh, I see..." Seahawk coughed nervously while looking at a particular stack on unpaid bills nailed to a board behind the counter. "In that case, I guess one more soft drink can't hurt. What can I get you?"

"We want something sweet," Catra replied while pointing over to Adora, who waved like a dork. "Something from one of those bottles up there."

The look of considerable concern in Seahawk's eyes grew more noticeable, at least to any other responsible adult in the vicinity.

"Oh, no can do," he replied while tapping the bar. "But you know what - I think I have something you might like. I usually just make them for my beloved, you know, so consider yourselves honored to enjoy such a divine treat."

"If you say so," Catra replied flatly before the bartender turned and disappeared through the kitchen door. A minute or so later, he returned with a tall sundae glass in hand, its sides overflowing with a milky beverage. A single, nuclear red cherry stared down from its peak like some candy-coated sentinel.

"Behold - my latest triumph of mixological innovation! A beverage made of milk and ice cream - perfect for cooling down on a summer day or sharing with a special friend. And to you, I offer it free of charge."

Setting the frosty glass on the counter, the bartender tucked in a pair of bendy straws and adjusted the cherry. After running over,

Adora's eyes glistened in its wake, their appetite suddenly redoubling.

How did Catra know those are my favorite?

"A milkshake! Fuck yeah!"

Jumping up and seizing the glass, Adora stared down at the drink as if it were the gods' ambrosia itself. As they pulled in a drag of the sweet cream, Seahawk tried to lodge his disagreement, to no avail.

"It's not just a milkshake! It was conceived in my limitless imagination, crafted by these artful hands. Taste it and see, it is more than your pedestrian milkshake."

"Looks like a milkshake," Catra concluded categorically. "But it looks like they likes it. So, thanks."

Hopping down off her barstool and following Adora out toward the porch, she paused at the threshold and offered a wink in Adora's direction.

"Oh wait, almost forgot the most important part. Mom taught me this one. Hey, mister!"

Seahawk leaned back over the counter, a wash rag now in hand.

"Yes, do you need something else?"

"Yeah - *put it on my tab.* "

***

Their eyes were bigger than their stomachs, the pair quickly realized between sips of malted milk and dark chocolate chunks. But still, they persevered, drinking down every last drop of their

hard-earned prize until only the cherry remained, glistening in the moonlight with a smile that said, "there's enough preservatives in me to outlast the heat death of the universe." It was a good match for the table, as it turned out, and afterward, Catra can't help but look at its chipped, nauseating surface without feeling a fond warmth weave its way through her bones.

For now, though, as she licked the last of their winnings off a long, narrow spoon, Catra's eyes were fixed on Adora, who had started naming off all of their favorite ice cream flavors almost as soon as they sat down. Without missing a beat or stopping for so much as a breath, they'd moved onto her favorite sodas, listing off a veritable rainbow of sweet drinks Catra had never even heard of before. That is, except for one particular pop right at the end, at which point, Catra knew she had to interject.

" Sidral Mundet. That's what it's called."

Adora tipped their spoon back into the empty glass, allowing it to slide down to the base with a hearty clink.

"That's what what's called?"

"The apple soda you tried, the one you didn't know the name of. If it came in a glass bottle, then that's probably what it was."

"Whoa, really?" Adora looked intrigued now, having spent the better part of the hour info dumping about their favorite sweets to a girl they'd only just met. "I had it at a party once, some other kid brought them to share. But I haven't seen them at the store since, and mom doesn't know where to buy them."

Catra scoffed and pushed the empty sundae glass aside. "Seriously? They have them at the international market in town. My mom...Ms. Weaver shops there sometimes and I sneak them into her basket. They've got more flavors, too, from a bunch of other countries."

"More...flavors?" Adora half-mumbles, full awe setting into their dinner-plate eyes.

"Yep! A whole bunch. Like, there's these ones with a marble in the cap that you have to knock out to drink the soda. It's super cool."

"That sounds amazing! I want to try that. And the apple soda, too. What'd you say that store was called again? Maybe I can get my mom to take us sometime. Or your mom, if she'd be okay with that. Either way, we have to go there! Maybe we can go tomorrow? Are you doing anything tomorrow? Because I just have soccer practice in the morning and...oh."

Adora's warp-speed prattle trailed off at the pass as they noticed a shadow creeping into Catra's expression. She looked grumpy again, just as she had when they'd rescued her from her picnic table prison earlier, and a certain timid stitch started to appear at the corners of her eyes.

Something had changed all of a sudden, Adora could quickly tell, and based on the way Catra's eyes drifted up and out toward the veranda without warning, whatever was causing it was coming their way.

It didn't take long for Adora to learn the gloom's origin, even with their back still turned toward the pub. Nothing carries like a mother's voice, after all.

"Catrina! There you are! I've been looking all over for you, young lady, and I was this close to calling the police to put in a missing person's report. I swear, if you keep running off like, I won't be bringing you with me on my outings anymore. You'll just be staying at home for the rest of the summer. Is that what you want?"

By the time she finished, the woman herself loomed tall over the both of them, casting an impressive shadow despite the moon's crescent phase. Though her glass was gone, a fog of tannins and gossip rolled off her tongue, a haze enough that even Adora noticed it and tried to place the scent. It was strong, whatever it was, and it didn't take long for Adora to learn what effects it apparently imparted on its imbiber's temper.

"Are you even listening to me, Catrina? I said - is that what you want?"

Slumping down slightly, Catra shook her head reluctantly. "No, ma'am."

"I didn't think so. Now, we must go. There's still laundry you need to fold when we get home. And don't think I didn't notice the dishes you hid in the dishwasher. You know full well that those are antiques that must be hand-washed."

"Yes, ma'am."

"And another thing - what's happened to your hair? I spent so much time getting it to lay down naturally this morning and now you've gone and ruined it and -"

Ms. Weaver looked over suddenly, realizing at once that her tirade had not been to an audience of one. She hadn't seen this child before and immediately, something in their invisible pedigree caught her keen eye.

"Oh, my apologies. I didn't see you there...?"

Adora offered a polite smile, as their mom had taught them when speaking to strangers - even mean, creepy strangers.

"Adora. My name's Adora. I use they/she pronouns."

"Ah, good to know, Adora." Ms.Weaver nodded and placed a bony hand on Catra's shoulder. "I am Catrina's mother and I've been looking for her all evening. Were you two playing, perhaps?"

The allusion to their afternoon escapades turned Adora's smile from standard issue to crisp and genuine in a heartbeat.

"Yeah, we were! We ran all around the park and through the fountains. Catra even found a squirt gun - it was so much fun."

Curling her lips and nodding, Ms. Weaver turned her gaze back to her ward. "I see. And that is despite the fact I specifically told her not to leave the patio without asking, yes?"

Catra remained silent, her eyes frozen on the chipped tabletop between them. Adora was all-too happy to respond in her stead.

"Oh, I didn't know about that. I'm sorry if that's caused you any trouble. It's just, she looked so bored over here and I'd been looking for someone new to play with all day and..."

Ms. Weaver raised a reassuring hand and cut the blonde off. "No need to apologize, Adora, not for my daughter's mistakes. You look quite bright yourself, so do not let her be a distraction to you. I'm glad you had a nice time, though, even if you both look a bit...damp."

"Anyway," she continued as she tightened her grip and hoisted Catra up, "we must be going. House chores won't do themselves, after all. Say goodnight, Catrina."

Catra's eyes flashed up from the ground, long enough for Adora to catch a gut-wrenching helplessness muddled into her blue-and-pale-yellows.

"Goodnight, Adora."

Ms. Weaver's boots started to click off toward the parking lot as Catra turned and started to follow after. But as soon as her guardian was out of earshot, she scuttled back to the table and pulled up close to Adora's ear.

"I can get you those apple sodas, I promise. Meet me here tomorrow, same time?"

Adora eyes grew wide again as a butterfly or two tickled at their insides. As if they could ever say 'no' to Catra.

They nodded.

"You know it."

Autumn

Chapter Summary

> The season of decay settles in, but something is blossoming between the pair. Or, it would be, if either of them could buck up the courage to talk about *that* .

Chapter Notes

> Let's play a game - which dork can address the elephant in the room first? Any guesses? Any bets?
>
> Anyway, enjoy this chapter! And pay no attention to the fact that the chapter count ticked up one. There's gonna be a bonus chapter and it's already shaping up to be a real treat.

2012

"You didn't have to pay for this, you know? My job at the coffee shop pays me plenty."

Adora took another drag off their shared milkshake - dark chocolate, their favorite. They'd tried just about every flavor under the sun by now and even some known only to Seahawk. But they always came back to dark chocolate in the end, so perfect and bitter and sweet.

"I know you do and of course I did. It's not everyday you get offered a big time scholarship to one of the best programs in the country. I mean, maybe that level of praise is normal for you, but I consider it an accomplishment. So, drink up."

With a flourish, Catra stabbed her straw into the shared drink, its whipped cream head already beginning to slip beneath the glass' rim. If she didn't move quick, Adora's seemingly endless appetite would drink it all down on her own - just like the last three times.

Adora grinned and glanced over at the lavender-and-gold folder resting at the other end of the table. Their coach had broken the news after practice, that Adora had been offered a provisional full ride to the University of Etheria and a starting spot on their soccer team. A few hours had passed since then and Adora still wasn't sure if it had settled in - a collegiate athlete, a real chance to go pro if she wanted, and all of that before their senior year. *No one pinch me* , they thought - if this was a dream, then she never wanted to wake up.

"Yeah, okay - I guess that is a bit of a big deal," Adora conceded. "But seriously, I didn't expect them to make an offer already. I mean, we still have all of senior year to play. Why would they want me to commit so early? The season's not even over."

Catra shrugged. "Probably because you're the best striker in the entire conference. And I'm sure they were totally charmed the minute they talked to you. They wouldn't be the first."

"Right, sure, that *has* to be it." Adora drew another sip - real chocolate chunks all the way down. Seahawk had really outdone himself this time. "Makes me wonder when you'll get yours."

"Get my what?"

Catra raised an inquisitive eyebrow, which Adora met with only partial exasperation.

"Get your scholarship offer, duh! You're bound to get one. You've been playing for as long as I have."

"Technically. I only joined that kids league because it was an excuse to get out of the house...and because you were in it."

"Right, you were a natural from day one, especially when coach started you out front. I bet those college scouts are writing up all kinds of offers for you right now, just you wait."

Catra rolled her eyes and reached a hand into her bag. Around them, the first signs of autumn had started to show on the trees

in goldenrod and flaxen hues. Over in the park, a few youngsters laughed and chased one another, in and out of accumulating leaf piles until their parents called them home.

"Don't bet too much on it. Most colleges don't like delinquents who get kicked out of class every other week."

Narrowing her eyes, Adora tried their best to keep a straight face. Catra wasn't wrong, exactly, but there was still reason to be optimistic. Catra deserved a good break, after all, at least one good thing in her life to look forward to. In secret, Adora also hoped such a scholarship would come emblazoned in lavender and gold. That way, they could take on the next big adventure together, shoulder to shoulder, there for each other every step of the way - they way it was meant to be.

"I'm sure they look at more than just your discipline record. Grades are part of it, too."

Shuffling through her bag some more, Catra finally withdrew her well-loved pencil case - an adorable space kitty with a burgundy body and sapphire mane - and tossed it onto the table, alongside a dog-eared moleskine notebook. She then cracked the notebook and leafed through to the first blank page.

"Right, because all of those college recruiters are gonna look at my report cards and say 'oh wow, how did we miss such a *genius* before?' You and I both know I don't get very good grades."

Catra continued to lay the sarcasm on hard, much to Adora's irritation. She was deflecting again, as she often did when their idle chatter hit close to home. A twinge in Adora's gut reminded them that this probably wouldn't be their last consequential conversation before the day was out. They still had *that* to talk about, after all...

"You *do* get good grades, though," Adora insisted, "when you actually turn work in on time. Speaking of which - don't forget to

turn in our lab notebook tomorrow. You know how Mr. Hordak feels about late work."

Even as they leaned over to grab the notebook in question from their backpack, Adora could feel Catra's eyes roll like loaded dice.

"Yep, uh huh - got it. Thanks for the reminder." Accepting the notebook, Catra tossed it lazily aside and went back to her sketchbook, where a brisk, yet calculated outline was already appearing in graphite grey strokes. "Anyway, I'm not holding my breath for any scholarships. I'll just save them for all the try-hards like you."

Pouting slightly, Adora sat back and fell silent. Try-hard or not, it felt wrong to let Catra just settle like that, not when there were chances to go places on the line - not when their plan was on the line.

"Well, either way, I really think you should apply to some bigger schools. I think most college teams would be lucky to have someone as smart and as quick as you up front."

"Yeah, right." Catra turned her notebook sideways and continued sketching, the loose, breathy form of her opposite beginning to appear on the page. "You and I both know you're the one making me look good out there. And besides, I don't really want to play after we graduate. I don't want to go pro, so what's the point?"

"Okay." Adora glanced down at the notebook and saw themself, Catra's most common subject as of late. They tried to put the probable reason out of mind. "Then, what about an arts school? You could probably pull together enough pieces to submit a portfolio. I've heard Halfmoon College of Art and Design has a really good apprentice program."

HCAD was also a 20 minute train ride over from their future collegiate home, Adora knew - they'd researched as much the day after Bright Moon scouts visited their team practice. They had to be ready for every eventuality.

Catra still looked uninterested, as if she'd already turned over the idea and found it molding on the other side.

"Pass. Those places are always just full of stuck up trust fund kids, anyway. Makes sense since they cost about a billion dollars a year to attend. And supplies, don't even get me started. You wouldn't believe what they charge for erasers, goddamn *erasers* ."

Adora frowned again, this time a little deeper at their best friend's repeated denials. Reaching over, they nabbed their trapper keeper from their back pack and paged through it until a pair of lime green forms came into view, the first filled in with neat cursive and the second blank.

"Well, if neither of those are an option...what are you going to put on your post-grade ideation form? They're due next Friday."

The table momentarily shook as Catra started furiously erasing an errant dash, leaving a trail of ashy white rubber bits in its wake. With the nubby eraser still in hand, she looked up and gestured toward the sickly form.

"Oh, that? I'm not turning it in."

Bright Moon High School's resident rule follower wasn't hearing it.

"What do you mean you're 'not turning it in?' You heard what the counselors said during home room - they won't let us register for classes next semester until we turn it in."

"I don't care. They always forget stuff like that, anyway. And really, what're they gonna do, make me drop out over a stupid scrap of paper? I don't think so."

"You're probably right." Adora slipped their own completed form back into the binder and nabbed out a pen. "But isn't there anywhere you want to apply to? It doesn't have to be for soccer or art - it could be anywhere."

And by "anywhere," Adora gently hoped their opposite would lean toward any of the several small or mid-sized institutions of higher learning that dotted the Bright Moon Valley region. Queens College, Moonstone State, the Academy of Historic Enterprises - anywhere, just not anywhere too far.

"It doesn't really matter. I'm not going to college. Sorry to break your heart over it."

Adora indeed felt their heart shudder at the thought, but they endeavored to keep calm.

"Catra, that's ridiculous. Of course you are. How else are you gonna get a good job? Without a degree, you won't be able to...

"Yeah yeah, I've heard it a million times from the counselors. Believe it or not, 'getting a good job' isn't really my whole goal in life."

"It's not mine, either, not really. But it's a start." Adora looked down at the blank page again and looked back to Catra, whose pencil strokes have grown darker and harder. "If you don't want to go to college then...what do you even want to do?"

As the question floated out into the crisp air, Catra's pointed pencil flicks and measured glances puttered slowly to a stop. Utensil in hand, sketchbook still spread on the nuclear red table, Catra stared down at her half-finished work in silence. A gentle breeze passed through, tussling her hair and rustling the dry trees above before she spoke again, the witty color of her voice replaced with a chiaroscuro deadpan.

"Like I said, it doesn't matter. I'm not good at anything. And even if I was, it's not like I'd be able to just up and leave. So, I figure, why try."

The breeze fell flat all of sudden, as if the air had been sucked out of the room. Adora's lung's felt the same, to hear their best friend so resigned to an enviable fate. There was so much left unsaid there, not least the way Catra's mother hung an eclipsing shadow

over everything on the young woman's horizon. It felt now, as another bout of weighted silence settled between the long-time friends, that Catra had become adjusted to that inumbrate world, darkened beyond recognition until any hope of escape felt Orphian at best.

Adora's throat felt scratchy all of a sudden, but they didn't reach for their melting milkshake. Instead, they leaned forward and gently cupped Catra's hand, pencil and all. Instinctively, their fingers wove together, closer always if they had the chance.

"That's not true," they started in, squeezing their hands together without a second thought. "You're good at all kinds of things. Like these."

Adora swiped the sketchbook with their free hand and started leafing through it before Catra snatched it back with a covetous glare.

"Hey! Don't look at those, they're not finished..."

"I know. It's just...they're all amazing. Everything you create is amazing. Your drawings, your paintings, even these sketches - they're all miles beyond what most people can just pull out of their head. You're so incredibly talented - just like Madame Razz said."

Catra’s cheeks rose slightly, though she refused to make eye contact with such saccharin praise.

"That old coot is crazy and you know it."

"She gets a little mixed up with time," Adora nodded, sensing some of the shadows dissipating from Catra's eyes. "But she knows talent when she sees it. You heard her after the art final last year - you have what it takes to really make it as an artist. You have vision, you have drive, you don't take shit from people and you're just...you're the coolest person on earth. So, don't say you can't do anything. You can - *I* believe you can. You can do anything, Catra. I believe in you."

The autumn breeze began to blow again, hassling their hair and loosening an errant tear from Catra's glassy eyes. It was all she could do to hold back a real torrent, the true way she wanted let this gutting feeling out of the cage in her soul. But instead, she simply squeezed back, hard and tight, her lips curling in as she tried with all her might to keep her heart off her sleeve. Swallowing hard, she finally looked up and caught Adora's gaze, her cheeks warming before the right words could form in her mouth.

"Yeah, yeah, you're just saying that. Who paid you, huh?"

Adora couldn't help but chuckle at the idea. "No one paid me. I really mean it. Don't let *her* be the reason you hold back, that's all I'm saying."

As quick as she met it, Catra broke the connection and looked down at the table, her heart pounding out a haphazard rhythm.

"It's not her, it's...it's...." She swallowed hard again, deciding now wasn't the right time. It could wait, maybe forever. They didn't need to talk about *that* ever again.

"I just don't want to talk about it right now."

Adora could tell she meant it, too, from the way she tensed at the proposition. Pushing wouldn't be worth it, not with so much of this kind autumn day left to enjoy. So, they sighed and squeezed Catra's hand once more, warm and caring, supportive to the last.

"Well, if you do want to talk about it, I'm here. Okay? I care about your future and I just want you to be happy with where it takes you."

Catra let her scowl soften slightly, like parched earth opening up to a nourishing rain.

What'd I ever do to deserve them?

"Whatever, dummy. I know you're not going anywhere. Not yet."

***

A couple weeks on and the season of decay began to show its true colors.

The once-fiery trees throughout the park began shedding their coats and wilting, a reminder to passersby that it was time to pull their own jackets on a little tighter. The sun above shied further and further toward the horizon with each passing day, glazing the town in sepia tones that made it hard to not feel a little nostalgic. Even the children in the park couldn't ignore the season's shifting tides, their freedom to run and play growing thinner and thinner with the early-setting sun.

And through it all - through countless hours of sienna-hued practice, countless hours spent pouring over frantically-scribbled notes, countless hours staying up late and watching old TV movies and talking about... *you know, whatever* - the topic never came up. The fall grew more somber with each passing day and somehow, they never managed to talk about *that* . The elephant in the room, the albatross around her neck - no matter what she decided to call it, Catra wanted nothing more than to forget about the whole transgression. With any luck, Adora and their head full of lofty dreams would do the same.

By now, though, Catra hardly thought about it. A nervous flinch at Adora's voice here, a stroke of blush when they brushed shoulders there, but nothing serious - nothing fatal. All of that could be kept under wraps for...Catra wasn't sure how long. But there was no way around it. They couldn't talk about it now, not after all these weeks - not after she got suspended over it. It was dead and gone and lost forever, a single blip in a perfect friendship that Catra pleaded with the universe, day in and day out, to not ruin for her.

Most of those days, it felt like the one good thing in her life.

"Are you sure you're feeling okay?"

Catra clicked off her phone and stuffed her hands back into her jacket pockets. The post-practice warmth pulsed in her veins, but her hands were still starting to get cold.

"Because I thought that first ball to the head was an accident. The second time you looked...what was it Netossa said? Distracted."

Adora rubbed the side of their head, the phantom of both impacts still humming just below the surface.

"I'm not distracted!" they insisted, pouting just as they had when Netossa leveled the original accusation. "I'm just...I've had something on my mind all day. All week, really."

Catra narrowed her eyes. "Distracted" might have been an understatement.

"If it's about accepting that scholarship, I don't know what you're waiting for. They're not going to offer you more money or anything if you hold back, so there's no point in keeping the entire town in suspense."

Glancing down at the leaf-covered sidewalk below their feet, Adora's throat grew a touch dryer.

"It's not that...it's about..."

"Is it about your major? Because I swear, if you stay awake tonight texting me the pros and cons of taking an accelerated track again, I'm going to block your number."

Adora drummed their fingers on their backpack strap and watched a squirrel scamper up a nearby tree, nut in hand. "It's not that, either. I...um...actually, I wanted to talk about..."

The pair crossed the threshold to the Sword and Pegasus just then, their favorite table now in view under a smattering of dry, wispy oak leaves. Adora's eyes flashed to the table, then to the door that led to the pub's interior. That could buy a few minutes, they thought, so they jogged forward a few nervous steps and jabbed a thumb toward the building proper.

"Actually, I'm going to get the milkshake. Dark chocolate still good?"

"Yeah, sure."

Catra nodded and started over toward the table before turning back and smirking.

"Actually, I kinda want something different today. Surprise me."

Fortunately for Adora, another nippy breeze across the patio made it easy to hide the chill running down their spine. Hearing words like that out of Catra's mouth before, it hadn't meant much more than an idle invitation. But lately, since *that* happened, it felt like her every word had been dip-dyed a new shade, a touch more red if Adora's cheeks were any indicator. They'd done their best to hide it all the while, but the kettle was beginning to bubble over. Catra was getting messy with her words again and it was making it hard to concentrate on anything at all.

A couple minutes and an encouraging conversation with Seahawk later, Adora reappeared on the veranda, a strawberry milkshake in one hand and a flickering spark of confidence in their core. Talking to themself in the mirror this morning hadn't been enough, it seemed, and Adora was worried that by the time they reached the table, they'd dissolve into an anxious, sweaty puddle that vaguely resembled the third-best goal scorer in Bright Moon High history.

Why was this still so scary?

After reaching the table, Adora gingerly set down their backpack and the glass before settling in with a heavy sigh. This was it,

they reminded themself, and tried to act natural. Catra knew a bad actor when she saw one, though.

"Okay, now I know something's wrong. You always take a drink out of these before you even sit down. Did that ball really hit you that hard? Do you have brain damage? Please don't have brain damaged."

Adora tried their best to look small, not imposing in the slightest.

"I'm not brain damaged. And I'm just not that hungry today."

Catra pulled the milkshake over and took the first brassy swig instead, no straw needed.

"Okay, then what's so big and scary that it has you shaking in your boots? You don't even get like this before a match anymore."

"That's because," Adora started in before faltering. They grabbed the hem of their letterman jacket and tried their best to avoid eye contact. "That's because this is more important than soccer."

Catra cut another smirk and rolled her eyes, her over-confident heart already forgetting.

"Oh, wow. I didn't think I'd *ever* hear you say that. So, what is it, then? You gonna tell me?"

Gripping their jacket even tighter, Adora felt their heart push its way into their throat. It was pain and heat and the burning sensation of holding a secret by the tail while it howled and scratched for its freedom. The resolve was there, but their grip was slipping fast. They had to say it now, before it turned around and had a chance to bite the hand that fed it.

Swallowing hard, Adora finally released their grip on their jacket. Crisp, aloe-ed air rushed in to fill its place across their trembling palms.

"Okay, so. You're right, I was kinda distracted during practice. But it's not about school or the scholarship or any of that. It's about...there's...there's something else I want to talk about - something *we* need to talk about."

Now, the tawny spotlight turned to Catra's side, illuminating her mismatched eyes just as they grew wide with recognition. Panic drummed her pulse into a quick frenzy, but she tried to maintain her composure. Maybe she'd simply misheard.

"Oh, yeah? What's that? Wait, let me guess - you want a report on the glamorous life from out-of-school suspension? Because let me tell you - that was probably the single best week of my life. Didn't have to get up early, didn't have to put on that stupid uniform, didn't have to deal with Hordak, didn't have to...."

Adora cut back in, their nerves insisting on nothing less than an attentive audience.

"No, it’s not about that. Not entirely. What I was wondering was..."

They looked up now and managed to catch Catra's mortified glare. There she was. There *she* was.

They couldn't keep this in any longer. Just above a mumble, their eyes locked on to their best friend in the world, they finally asked.

"Do you...do you remember, after the game a couple weeks ago..."

Adora didn't need to say another word. Catra's heart gave a final, thunderous clap and it all rushed back before her eyes.

***

The neon lights of Bright Moon always hit different after a big match and this particular Saturday was no different. Hours after the stadium emptied, hours after both teams trudged home for some well-earned sleep, two pairs of sneakered feet plodded up a side street across town, bathed in the greenish glow of mercury vapor lamps above. They'd flipped the script this time around, the faded red Chuck Taylors leading the trendy monochrome trainers by a handful of paces. An unusual silence hung between them as well, silence filled with ease by the idle sounds of commuter trains they'd forgone in lieu of the long way home.

But all the same, their bodies thrummed as one - thrummed with the fulfilled anticipation of the match, danced with adrenaline that had been their elixir, pulsed with the cheers of the crowd as they cut and dove and tore up their knees trying to keep the opposing offense at bay. Most of all, their hearts beat as one from the last kick of the game onward, when a perfectly-timed cross from Catra landed square at Adora's feet. Instinctively, Adora found the back of the net and secured them a spot in the league cup just as the final whistle blew.

Adora's mind wasn't on the game-winning goal, though, as they shuffled back into the locker room, still dripping orange and blue from their Gatorade bath. They'd relished all the cheers, all the claps on the back from their ecstatic teammates and coaches, sure, but it wasn't why their skin still teamed with energy and neon-colored sports drink. Instead, their mind hummed with the fleeting moments following the goal, when they'd found Catra across the way and ran in for a celebratory embrace.

Catra's arms were what they'd been looking for, what she'd expected and always cherished after years of joyful amity. But Catra's arms were not what they'd found, at least, not entirely.

As they collided like vibrant young stars at the galaxy's core, Adora looked deep into her opposite's mismatched eyes, hoping to drink down the adrenaline that welled-up in their blue-and-pale-yellow recesses. There instead, their own cornflower blues found something else entirely, something new they'd never seen in all

their years of tree-climbing contests and last-minute sleepovers, shared milkshakes and a million pinky promises. This was an unknown quantity altogether, a new sort of luminous passion, and in its brilliant gleam, Adora's heart couldn't help but ask...

"Is that...is she going to...?"

The answer required no words. Time slowed all around them and the crowd faded away, leaving them alone in the world at the head of the 6-yard box. Nothing more needed to be said - not that they would have heard each other over the feverish ringing in their ears. This electricity was real enough and the sparks were already starting to fly. All they had to do now was lean in just a touch, Catra's head turned ever so slightly. The rest was pure, ethereal bliss and the roar of the crowd.

All of that was miles away now, literally and figuratively, left on the pitch with so much chalk and sweat. Now, on the first truly cool night that made summer's humidity feel like a bad dream, Adora paced after the girl who had invited them close in front of the city's spellbound eyes, their mind still desperate to know what and why and for how long.

Finally, after miles and miles without a word, her pace unyielding, Catra ground to halt just blocks from the house she'd been loath to call a "home." There, a civic spotlight upon her, she turned to face her pursuer, the tension of the chase growing too great to bear. The taste in her mouth still lingered and it made Catra want to spit.

Before she could speak, though, Adora was there, just outside the streetlight's glow, staring her down like she was a golden fleece on the run.

"Catra, finally! Why'd you leave so fast? Everyone wanted to congratulate you and I wanted to talk and..."

"You know why I left."

The reply, sharp and silver, cut through the still, evening air and slashed at Adora's chest. Catra regretted the aggression immediately and winced, her ears flattening as she tried to avert her gaze.

"You know why I left and I'm sorry. What I did wasn't okay. It was stupid and impulsive and...I didn't ask. And now everyone's going to give you a hard time about it and I'm probably going to get kicked off the team and it's going to ruin our friendship and it's all my fault. So, I'm sorry. I'm sorry."

Adora took a skittish step closer, their heel grinding hard into the salt-worn blacktop. Even from that distance, they could see the mirrored tears forming in Catra's typically fierce eyes.

"No, no, don't be sorry. It was...it was good, actually. I didn't mind, I mean. It's just..."

Adora faltered as they traced a finger over their lips, recalling the moment their heart nearly stopped for good. Catra didn't see it that way, though, her ears hanging instead on those last two words, their impending weight already cutting into her slender shoulders. It was just as she feared on all those red-eyed nights, but the reality of rejection was still a bitter pill to swallow, a cap of cyanide she'd wedged between her own razor-sharp teeth.

There it was again, that desire to spit.

"Oh. So that's how it is."

Catra turned the rest of the way and took a step back into the night, eager to put the work of lifelong friendship behind her. But Adora wouldn't give up, not now, not on the girl who'd just risked so much just to say, "you, and only you."

"Catra, wait!"

Squeezing their fists tight, Adora dashed forward and reached out a desperate hand. To their surprise, their desperate fingers found

prize on a handful of crimson fabric, stopping Catra in her tracks and forcing her to remain.

"What I mean is, it was more than good. I'm incredibly flattered, believe me. I'm still trying to process it all and I just.. I don't know if I'm ready for..."

A crack from Catra's knuckles echoed into the night as she shoved the apple of her eye away, nearly knocking them to the ground. As she watched Adora stumble, she felt something inside her finally snap. The poison in her bones had finally made it to her heart.

"Great, because I'm clearly not 'ready' for that, either. Who knows if I'll ever be 'ready' because clearly, I don't deserve anything good. How about we just make everyone happy and forget this ever happened? Everything will just go back to normal and you'll keep being team captain and I'll get suspended and you'll keep worrying about college and I'll keep worrying about you, like I ever had any fucking chance."

"So don't worry about me. It wouldn't be worth it. I wouldn't want to push you if you're not 'ready.'"

Adora tried to reach out again, but it was already too late. They knew now what they wanted and she was slipping through their fingers.

"Catra, wait! That's not what I meant!"

Their plea rang hollow, the night as capricious as it was vast. They gave chase again, but Catra never said another word - not that night when she slammed the door in their face, not the next day at school or at practice, not for weeks and weeks and weeks after. It was as if she'd forgotten the moment they stepped off the turf, their shared euphoria lost as quickly as it had bloomed.

Adora couldn't forget about it, though, not in their dreams or their days spent next to each other in every other class. They couldn't forget it in Catra's smile, nor the way her tail curled up when she

laughed. They couldn't forget it in the way their hands wove so perfectly together, or the way she always found a home in their lap when no one else was looking, asking to stay just a few minutes longer, even when the festival fireworks had long since faded back into the black, unyielding night.

They couldn't forget it, end of story, and more than anything, they didn't want to forget.

They wanted to remember. They had to remember. Their lips still felt a shade of that warmth and there was no ignoring it.

They wanted more.

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Catra whipped her head to one side, her flustered cheeks scarcely hidden behind her lancing words.

"I already said I'm sorry, didn't I? We don't have to talk about this anymore. In fact..." Catra began to rise, stuffing her sketchbook and pencil pouch into her bag in a single, hap-hazard motion that narrowly avoided upending the half-empty milkshake. "I have to go. Now."

Feeling the warm, bitter tears returning, Catra ducked her head and readied herself to again turn tail. But as before, something caught her arm and wouldn't let her go. Looking back, it was Adora's hand wrapped tight around the back of her sleeve, their eyes turned upward, frightened and peppered with the shreds of some desperate, flagging determination.

"Catra, no! Please, stay. I still want to talk about it because I...because I..."

Adora's hand slid down the sleeve and caught in Catra's hand, trembling slightly as the truth finally trickled out. Everything in Catra's rabbit heart screamed for her to run, to hide, to never let this impulsive mistake hurt her again. But through the cacophony, through her calcified doubts, she didn't let go. She held firm, let out a tenuous sigh, and settled back into her seat.

Smiling gently at the sight, Adora traced their thumb over the ridge of Catra's knuckles and continued.

"I said I wasn't ready before because I didn't know. I didn't know you felt like that about anyone - about me."

"Well, I do. Ya happy?" Catra gritted her teeth and tried her best to look menacing, but a purr deep in her throat made it hard to maintain the guise. "Now can we never talk about this again, please?"

"No, I want to because I..." Adora's voice quivered as they squeezed Catra's hand again, ever so softly, just like on the first day. "Because I feel like that, too."

She thought she'd misheard at first, her ears failing her right at the moment of truth. But somehow, her heart still heard it, and Catra's awe-stricken eyes told the tale.

"I like you, Catra. I always have. You mean the world to me and I should have realized that sooner. I used to wonder why I always had butterflies in my stomach when you laughed at my jokes or why I always wanted to try so hard to impress you. I didn't even understand why I wanted to do all of that elaborate junk to ask you to prom last year. But then you kissed me and it just...clicked."

Beneath the table, Catra jabbed her free hand into her chest, reminding her lungs that they had a job to do. Even through the dull pain, she cut a cathartic grin.

"Oh, so you're the one that put all that stuff in my locker? I knew you were acting fishy when I asked you about it."

"Yeah, that was me." They scratched the back of their head, sheepish but relieved. "I sorta chickened out at the last minute, though. That's why the last part didn't make any sense."

"Like I would have said 'yes' anyway."

Adora cleared their throat gently and dropped their gaze momentarily to the side.

"I mean, would you say 'yes' now?"

"To prom? I know you're brain damaged or whatever but I think it's a little late for that."

Adora leveled a knowing glare.

"No, not prom. To...us. I mean, if you want. If that's okay."

From across the table, Catra finally found it in herself to meet Adora's enchanted gaze, just as she had on that balmy night so many weeks ago, stadium floodlights pounding down their exhausted bodies. There, deep in a sapphire sea she ached to swim in forever, she saw the same spark, the same willingness, the same siren song that urged her forward, told her to seize the moment and worry about the consequences later. Then as now, she knew there was only one answer to a look like that.

And besides, she'd do anything at this point to whip that stupid grin off Adora's face.

With a long, slow blink, Catra tilted her head and pulled Adora forward and up to their feet. In their hands, so artfully woven together as pilgrims in prayer, she could feel their pulses thrumming in unison, their hearts beating as one again. After so many nights lying awake, asking, begging, pleading for another chance - she had it. She had them. Here they were. There they are.

As their lips met anew, Catra couldn't help but grin.

"Of course it's okay."

"God, you're such an idiot."

***

Later, as the waxing moon coasted through the autumn night, two pairs of sneakered feet rose from the table, their movements in harmony without even needing to say a word. In silence, save for the crickets crooning in the park grass beyond, they started their way home, hand in most lovable hand, the thought of missing curfew a distant shadow in their luminous world. For now, they had eyes only for each other and thoughts only for the way the other whispered as they ended a kiss. To them, they had invented something entirely new just now and nothing was going to stop them from relishing it until daybreak.

In their wake, silver moonlight glinted off the table's surface, revealing fresh cuts into its once-glossy veneer. Countless summers back, a pair of initials had been carved there, a peevish addition made with a pilfered pocket knife. Now, though, a new addition enclosed those jagged letters, a frame befitting of a new stage entered. Perhaps it was fitting, too, that the table was so virulently red - it made the heart glow that much brighter as the gravity of night began to settle in.

Spring

Chapter Summary

The cat returns.

Chapter Notes

checks calendar huh, looks like it's November tomorrow. And I'm over here still working on a September challenge. Timeliness? I wouldn't know 'er.

ANYWAY this and the bonus chapter are both finished! Right now! Can you believe it? So, expect this one to wrap up here in the next couple weeks! Even for the entirely-self-inflicted delays, this one's been fun to write - especially this chapter, which has one the best paragraphs I've written in a hot minute imho.

Enjoy the hurt/comfort, friends!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

2022

A full breath in, held warm within their chest. The ache's still there but the winter has dulled out its sharpest thorns. Spring rains won't make it bloom again, not after they buried it elbow deep and salted the ground as they walked away. With it out of sight, out of mind, they could just be present in this place, this park with memories as ringed as its trees. They could breathe again, if only for a little while, taking in what the season would offer and sipping down the idyllic feeling of returning to one's roots.

Releasing the breath, Adora opened their eyes and continued forward, the last few chords of an ageless song humming in their

earphones as they stepped off the paved park path and into the grassy expanse beyond.

Running over the same old ground, what have we found? The same old fears, wish you were here.

As the music faded back into silence, its tuned imitation of a faint, mooring breeze, Adora stepped up onto the porch and set eyes on their table, moved a few paces toward the door to make way for a newer rattan seating arrangement. It was a sight for sore eyes, to be sure, and it was probably a miracle the sad excuse for communal seating hadn't yet been turned into kindling. But Adora was glad to see it all the same - incandescent red surface and all.

Instinctively, as their hands traced over the table's chipped surface, looking for the marks and gouges that would prove they were there - that *she* was there - Adora was surprised to find the table's center plank covered by a linen tablecloth, the kind one might see at a more upscale establishment. It looked rather out of place here, on a rusting picnic table adjacent to a tavern best known for a flaming drink called the "Dragon's Daughter IV.' But Adora couldn't blame the establishment for wanting to spruce the old beater up. Besides, the carvings hadn't gone anywhere; they were still there, just out of view, jagged and heavy, a timeless scoring that had managed to not only proclaim their friendship and relationship but also, remarkably, outlive both.

A course, familiar pain spoke back up between Adora's fourth and fifth rib, the third time that morning. If they were going to enjoy any of this trip home, they'd have to learn to ignore it, even as it begged for yet more hours of restless attention and covetous feeding.

"Ah, now there's a familiar face!"

Adora pushed down the feeling once more and glanced up to see an iconic red kerchief strutting their way, a cheery face and bushy mustache bouncing just above its knotted center. Of course he'd be here, opening on a weekday where most customers wouldn't

wander in until lunch. He was the only person crazy enough to work at the Sword and Pegasus long enough to want to own it himself.

"Oh, Seahawk! Hi!"

Adora's renewed grin was met with a warm hug and a pat on the back. At least some things never changed.

"It's good to see you again, Adora. How has university life been treating you? And the bartenders, how are they over in that little college town?"

"Everything I could have hoped for and more," Adora replied reflexively. It wasn't entirely true, but it was a white enough lie. "And you know no one can compare to you. Not a single one of them would make me a milkshake, can you believe it?"

Seahawk pounded his fist against the table in mock frustration before raising the same hand skyward with a dramatic flair.

"Inconceivable! How can they consider themselves proper mixologists if they're unwilling to mix *any* drink a customer requests?"

"Beats me," Adora shrugged. "Clearly, they don't have your sense of adventure."

"Indeed, *adventure!"*

At such early morning gusto, Adora couldn't help but laugh a bit. Living with a theatre major like DT was one thing; seeing a true-to-life troubadour like Seahawk was always something else entirely, something far too easy to miss - home-sickening, even, if they thought about it for too long.

"Speaking of which," the bartender finally suggested after nodding back toward the shop door, " I was just opening up. I can shake up your old favorite if you want - on the house, for a penniless scholar like yourself."

Adora opened their mouth to accept before another pang - this time at the base of their rib cage and lancing down into their gut - reared its caustic head. A minute ago, a little dark chocolate and french vanilla would have been ambrosia to their soul. Now, all Adora could imagine was the bitter finish, each stomach-turning sip as unpalatable as the last. They winced at the thought and tried their best to play off their sudden loss of appetite.

"Um, actually, I'm not really that hungry. I was actually just going to sit here for a bit, if that's alright?"

"Fine by me." Seahawk crossed the porch and waved just as he stepped inside. "But if you need anything, you know where to find me. You two sure managed to that first day."

"Heh, right..."

It took a couple of restless minutes, but the new ache dissipated and Adora managed to settle in. The bench was, as ever, stiff and uncomfortable, bowing ever so slightly after years of uneven pressure and perniciously cold Decembers. It was familiar, though, and that was what mattered as Adora turned their gaze out toward the park, where the dark gloom of winter had started to subside, allowing the first few buds and eager bulbs to sprout from the timid soil. A little late snow wasn’t out of the question, but the land again was starting to regain its luster. The days were growing longer and once again, there was cause for hope in the pollinated air.

To Adora's eyes, however, it was all a green-gilded reminder. This time of year, there'd usually be bikes to ride, strawberries to pick, cherry blossoms to view, and babbling creeks to trudge through. None of that sounded appealing to Adora this trip around the sun, not least because they couldn't stomach the prospect of going alone. Besides going to practice, class, and the dining halls, they'd hardly been outside since winter skipped town, choosing instead to stay cloistered indoors, where the changing season could be enjoyed at a distance and where they could flick through their old phone photos in nostalgic peace.

This warmth, though, this early hint of genuine sunshine - they couldn't deny how nice it felt, like a blanket laid over their shoulders by invisible, matronly hands. They turned their gaze back to their table and pushed aside the table setting, revealing their old carvings to the light of day once more. Their head now resting against the table's surface, loose blonde locks willowing over the edge, they traced their fingers through the grooves, replaying the memories like an old phonograph playing out a favorite, scratchy tune.

A few more minutes on and the morning warmth started to wear on Adora's heavy eyelids. A night of fitful sleep had ended with a pre-dawn run, ostensibly to clear their mind, and now, that choice of motion over rest was beginning to catch up. Their head was already down, after all, and maybe if they just closed their eyes for a few winks, then they'd feel more ready to face the day. Just a quick little cat nap and then...

"Hey, Adora."

In a rush, Adora felt their body surge back to life, their limbs still heavy with the weight of hungry ghosts. The sensation turned their body rigged, forcing their eyes open and their body upright in a snap. Whatever that dream was, they'd heard *her* voice. But now it was gone again, replaced by a frenetic heartbeat and a sweltering heat across their skin, as if the early spring sun had turned it up to mid-August just to see them squirm.

Nearly panting, Adora wiped a bead of sweat from their brow and looked up from the table. How long they'd been out, they couldn't tell. What was apparent, though, was the sudden lack of sunlight landing on their face. A few heavy blinks later and Adora could see the cause - some stark, silhouetted form towering above the table, blocking out the burning star's most earnest beams and casting themselves in a holy penumbra that left Adora wondering for a moment if they were still lost in a dream.

Then, the shadowed form blinked, slow and purposeful, pale yellow and oceanic blue. They didn't say a word but Adora's heart

quickly resumed its sforzando pace, pressing their chest hard and fast with every sharp edge exposed. Even now, after months of radio silence, months without seeing her in the lovely flesh, Adora can't help but stare in awe, their mouth dropping open as the darkness stepped out of the light.

There she was - again.

"Catra! You're...you're here!"

And indeed, Catra really was there, one booted foot up on the bench, dressed from head to toe in clothy, congruent black. The sight at once brought a carmeled warmth to Adora's core and at the same time, strummed at the scar tissue that still patterned their heart. Catra simply nodded, the rising sun still dancing past her shoulders and getting lost in her wild mane.

"Yeah, I am. And I want to talk."

Flat and nearly emotionless, the words plucked another disquieting chord over Adora's veins. They swallowed hard and pulled their hands back to their side, worried that they might get burned if they were left too close to the approaching fire.

"Oh, okay. We can do that. Have a seat."

Tapping the table awkwardly, Adora realized at once that they sounded like a school counselor - sterile, acute, professional, maybe even a touch detached. It wasn't how they ever thought they'd speak to Catra, the girl who knew her every secret and with whom they'd have shared every star in the sky. But here they were, months of uninterrupted silence now behind them, half acting like this was just another sunny afternoon homework session. It was all they could do to keep from freezing up entirely.

Swallowing hard, Adora looked across the table and tried to meet their opposite's gaze.

"So, ummm...how have you been? Is everything okay?"

Catra scowled, leaving little room to question her mood.

"Cut the crap, Adora. I'm here because I wanted to say goodbye. I should have told you before you left for school. Better late than never, I guess."

"Goodbye? What are you talking about?" Adora searched Catra's expression for a reasoned explanation, but no answers transpired from the mist. All of a sudden, they couldn't read the tea leaves behind their best friend's eyes, save only the clear tension wound tight into her jaw. "Are you moving away or something? Because I'm still going to come back to visit every semester. And after I graduate we can...we can..."

"Doesn't matter. You've clearly got your whole life figured out already, so you don't need me in it. I'd just be a distraction."

Those words, they'd heard them before, but not on Catra's lips. She wasn't one to say things like that so matter-of-factly. Self-deprecating humor, sure, Catra offered that in spades, regardless of the situation. But something so genuinely self-effacing, that wasn't like her at all. If anyone was liable to lash Catra with whipping words like those, it would be...

"Miss Weaver..."

Adora mumbled the name under their breath before shaking their head and reaching for Catra's hand.

"Catra, you...you're not a distraction. You're just - you. We've literally done so much together - so much stuff I would never have tried without you. You're the one who pushed me to try out for team captain; you're the one who got me to ride a roller coaster for the first time; you're the one who stayed up every single night, helping me study for advanced placement exams even though you got nothing out of it. I'm going to my dream school now and that's only because you gave me the courage to finally re-apply."

With a gentle squeeze, Adora tried to make the words feel whole.

"Catra, I love you. You're not a distraction. You're you and I wouldn't have it any other way."

The sun above grew a little warmer, a little brighter as Catra looked down at her held hand. For a moment, she contemplated her opposite's words, contemplated squeezing back and accepting what they said as gospel. The guilty voice in the back of her head wouldn't drop it, though, and instinctively, she pulled her hand away.

"Sure, whatever. Then why'd you wait to apply in the first place, huh? That scholarship was yours and you turned it down because you were worried about me. Well, now you won't have to. You won't have me holding you back from doing what you want."

"That's not why I waited!" Adora insisted. "Of course I was worried about you - you're my best friend in the entire world and I didn't want to leave you behind. But..."

"But what, Adora?" Catra spat back. "You know it's true. You stayed because you took pity on me. You always have, ever since we met. You knew I'd be alone if you didn't talk to me and you knew I'd be pretty much alone once you skipped town. Guess what? You were right on both counts! But I don't want your pity anymore. Go follow your dreams or whatever you want. You don't need me."

You don't need me. You don't need me.

The thorn finally pushed its way through. In silence, as Catra's finite words rattled around inside their newly ruptured heart, Adora watched a hundred moments flash before their eyes, the projector threatening to burn the film as it spun relentlessly off the reel..

There she was, that awfully hot day in Stevenson Park, when Glimmer and Bow decided to stay home in the air conditioning and leave Adora out in the brandishing sun. Even when they spotted her from across the way, her vacant eyes trained on a

tepid glass of juice, Adora could sense something different about their future friend. Something in her stillness spoke to them, before they even had the words to know what those butterflies meant. Catra simply existed differently in their world, and for that reason, Adora made the first move. They just had to meet this girl with the mismatched eyes.

Then, she was running, running ahead, running with the kind of wild abandon that fulfilled all of her potential energy in a kinetic fanfare. She was always a few paces ahead, charging through the rain or clamoring up a snow pile, grinning with that special edge that revealed her perilous fangs to the world. It was always enough to make Adora forget for a moment that Catra was just a girl, a mortal being like themself, capable of all the good and ugly in this life when she wasn't busy marching to the beat of her own drum - thundering, electric, undeniable under any blue sky.

Sometimes they ran to escape, not play as they had in the park for so many years. Adora's bullies always had a way of catching up to them and when they did, they suddenly had a new set of steel-hewn claws to contend with. It was through such a fury, when the thugs from class 9-B decided that "they" just wasn't in their vocabulary, Adora could still see Catra standing firm, a crimson trickle chasing down her temple, her eyes alight with a flame that would have surely burned a forest if her claws hadn't sooner found their mark.

In those moments that stilled their world, Adora could always see Catra trembling, her hands coarse and shaky after connecting a sinking blow. All her life she'd been fighting, one way or another, and these moments were a reminder of how much she despised it, how she'd rather retract her knives for good and shuffle them away, never to be seen again in a life free of the gnawing need to strike first.

But even so, as it turned her throat ragged and threatened to crown her the school's right and proper social pariah, Catra stood her ground. She'd never say it aloud, in the heat of battle or the silent wound-licking that inevitably came after, but she'd always

put her body in harm's way for Adora. That reckless streak stung in every drop of hydrogen peroxide and still, she'd gladly walk through the valley of shadows again and again. With Adora there, she feared no evil; she could not want.

Save for that fateful night beneath the lights, when the world all but stopped and offered the opportunity her intemperate heart begged for. Maybe she should have asked, maybe it shouldn't have been such a right and proper surprise; but to Adora's memory, the glow still radiating from their first kiss shared, none of that mattered in the slightest. As they looked across the table and watched their best friend in a thousand lives tearing herself to shreds, Adora could only remember the way their lips fit together with perfect ease, and the way Catra looked up after they pulled apart - brilliant, awe-struck, and no longer inexorably afraid.

Adora blinked back to the present and the truth of the matter sat there in front of them. Perhaps what Catra had then they needed now. They clenched their fingers tight against their jacket hem and finally decided to stand firm.

"That's not why I waited," they started in, eyes straight ahead, tight with tears they were too afraid to show. "I waited because I need you, Catra. I needed you then and I need you now, even if I'm going to be a million miles away. I'm sorry you're hurting and for any part I had in that. But you have to believe me when I say that I love you, not because I pity you, but because I really, truly care about you - just you. Catra, you still mean the world to me and I can't imagine going through life without you, not after everything we've been through. That's why I waited - I was afraid to do it without you."

Catra opened her mouth to object, but Adora wouldn't be denied, the courage she so desperately needed finally beating a roaring blaze in her heart.

"You said I should do what I want. Well, guess what - that's what I've been doing this whole time. I wouldn't hold your hand like that, I wouldn't kiss you like that, I wouldn't stay up every other

night missing you like crazy unless I wanted to. And I do, Catra, I do. More than the scholarship, more than some dream job, more than anything else in the entire world - I *want* you, Catra, present tense. And now I'm too afraid to lose you. If it's something I did wrong, I can fix it, I promise. But please, *please* , stay. Stay with me. Stay with me."

Their peace finally declared, Adora couldn't hold back the flood any longer. They whipped their head down and away, biting the inside of their cheeks to keep the worst of the pain bridled. Whatever happened now, they'd said what they needed to. Now, if Catra still wanted to leave, she could walk away and there'd be no question on where they stood, together or alone, wherever life was ready to push them next.

Adora's heart heaved. And yet, Catra stayed.

It took a good minute for the shock of it all to settle in, Adora's ragged vulnerability washed against a cascade of tears she'd never seen from such peerless blue-grey eyes. But with a breath in of her own, Catra finally let herself feel the gentle sun above, its golden tresses warming her ochre skin through her unseasonal all-black attire. She'd hardened her heart against this moment, as ready as she was to attend a funeral for a friendship. Yet somehow, as they always managed to, Adora had performed a full-on miracle right before her eyes and turned lead straight into gold.

Catra allowed the silence to linger a few beats longer, at least until Adora could clear away the brunt of their tears. Off in the distance, a young jay twittered merely in its nest and Catra took its hopeful call as her cue. She leaned over and cut one of her famous, flirty smirks.

"Hey, you're still pretty cute when you cry, you know that?"

Cautiously, she reached across the table to take Adora's hand, but a swift kick in the shins stopped her in her tracks. Adora

meanwhile turned away further, trying desperately to knead the color from her cheeks with the palms of their hands

"Stop it, I am not."

"You are, though, and I'm not even joking."

Catra rose from her seat and tip-toed around to the other side, slotting herself in effortlessly at Adora's side without any argument.

"But if I had to choose, I'd prefer you without the tears. You're better with a smile. Always have been."

Adora's cheeks couldn't help but follow in kind, a sort of tenuous grin pushing through the haze of her still ragged feelings.

"Well, I'm glad I've got your approval."

"Hey, don't knock it. Most folks have to work for that kind of compliment. And here I am, giving it out to some total rando I just met at a picnic table next to some second-rate pub."

A gentle shove and Adora finally felt themself thawing.

"In your dreams. Like we could even pretend."

"Maybe we could, just for today."

Adora raised a curious eyebrow.

"Pretend what?"

Catra pressed a hand to the table's surface, her narrow fingers all but obscuring their initialized carving.

"Pretend we never met. Or pretend we just met. I could show you around town, take you to a movie, the park, whatever you want. Heck, we could run through the fucking splash pad again for all I care. Let's just make it a good time. I've missed that."

She looked right on at her partner, something bittersweet and distant in her gaze.

"I've missed you."

And for what it was worth, she meant it, heart and soul meant it. Adora heard it, too, and just for a moment, they could feel the thorn loosen, enough to let them feel hopeful again and play Catra's tactless little game. They rolled their eyes and scoffed.

"Sounds like a boring date to me. All the girls back at school always take me to nice restaurants or sports games if they want to impress me."

"Oh, so this is a date, now? That's pretty fast for someone I just met. But you know what? I think I can keep pace."

Rising quickly, Catra shook off the last of her ill mood and grabbed her girlfriend's wrist, hoisting them up in a single, fluid motion. Now toe to toe, she looked up at Adora, their eyes still a touch red but recovering slowly. In them, she wondered in silence how she could have ever questioned, wondered how Adora could forgive such a doubting Thomas. If there was a way for her to go back and see them again for the first time, though, she'd take it in a heartbeat. For now, she could at least pretend. Pretend, play along, and hope.

"But first," Catra jabbed a finger into Adora's shoulder, "you look like you've had a bit of a rough day. Bet some total jerk tried to break up with you for no good reason, yeah? I've seen it a million times before. She'd better be sorry for making someone as gorgeous as you cry."

"She's not a jerk," Adora corrected with a final sniffle, "and I don't know, she had her reasons, I guess. I'm glad she didn't, though. I could never replace her."

Dramatically, Catra pulled her hands from Adora's, miming as if she'd just touched a hot stove.

"Oh shit, she's still in the picture. I better leave you be then. Wouldn't want to be some creepy third wheel. Catch you later, cutie."

With a quick turn on her heels, Catra feigned like she was going to leave, tossing her wild mane off her shoulder dramatically as she went. But before she could even take a full step, an earnest hand nabbed her wrist, holding it tight like so many warm embraces before it.

"Come on, Catra. Don't make me say it again."

"Alright, alright." She winked and turned back to face the only smile she'd ever truly loved. "I'll stay. But it's not because I like you or anything."

Adora couldn't help but chuckle at the common refrain and Catra's ears were all too happy to hear such a joyful song, perking up to drink in every last melodious note and verse.

"Now, like I was saying, you look like you could use something to cheer you up. I hear this place has great milkshakes. Want one? My treat."

Chapter End Notes

> Wanted a chance to write "Wish You Were Here" by Pink Floyd into a fic for the longest time and wouldn't you know it, the chance presented itself 😉 and also, I think I've found my new writing niche - Biblical references but make them sapphic. It's what the people demand - nay, what they DESERVE!
>
> Annnnnyway hope y'all enjoyed this little wrap on the main story. But if you walked away thinking "damn that hurt/comfort hit just right, but I need some real tooth-rotting fluff to rebalance the humors", boy have I got a treat coming your way. EmileeDoodles. in all her infinite talent and majesty added a bonus piece to her already phenomenal set that this

fic is based upon. Soooooo bonus chapter it is - and you better believe this one's gonna be as sweet as wedding cake 

A New Season

Chapter Summary

Spring blossoms anew on an unforgettable night.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Oh, we *have* to have a photo over here! It's too perfect. Please, please, please?"

Catra turned in Bow's direction, his over-exuberant tone now grating after what felt like three eternities worth of staged photography. The mid-morning cocktails and a couple of Malort shots after lunch had helped cut the jitters, but it hadn't made their resident photographer any less irritating. She'd even joked, months and months back after the ring finally made an appearance, that she'd secretly drop his name from the guest list when Adora wasn't looking.

The blonde had only half-threatened divorce if she followed through.

"Where at?"

After stepping past another few reception guests, Catra could clearly see where her camera-laden friend was pointing. If it were at all possible, she'd have rolled her eyes all the way back.

"At your table, of course! We made sure it stayed open, just in case."

"Ah, right, *absolutely perfect* . Because nothing says 'I got dressed up in the nicest clothes I've ever owned to marry the love of my life' like a wide-angle portrait at a ratty old picnic table."

A hand found Catra's shoulder and offered a light, reassuring squeeze. The day had been hectic, sure, but at least they'd been there by her side through it all.

"Come on, Catra. It'll be cute. And besides, it'll be perfect for the scrapbook."

Straightening out her vest, Catra relented. If there's anything she'd learned throughout this entire matrimonial process, it was that Adora was usually right, at least when it came to matters of sentimentality.

"Yeah, okay, sure. Not like I've got anything else better to do."

"True," Adora nodded in agreement, espousal sword at her side. "The hard part's over now."

After a couple of minute's delay spent conversing with congratulatory guests, the pair finally ambled over to the well-worn table, assuming their usual seats as if this were any other spring evening.

There was no pretending on that count, of course. Why else would there be fairy lights and a hundred old-fashioned Polaroids strung from the willowy branches above? Why else would every friend from over the years be assembled on this worn brick patio, exchanging twice-told stories and joking about how they knew those two would end up together all along? To everything, there is a season and this season, this day, was theirs alone. It had taken years to get here, countless hours and weeks spent planning and laughing and sharing the sole fork at their first apartment together - but they had made it, and oh, what a splendid evening it was turning out to be.

Catra felt herself getting lost in the moment again until that irritating voice poked through her bubble with yet another command.

"Okay, now just act natural. Talk to each other - like I'm not even here."

"Yeah, Tech Boy, you and a hundred other people."

After sticking out her tongue scornfully, Catra turned back to face her newly-minted spouse. Their extremely early morning was starting to show through in their steely blue eyes, typically so radiant and lively and trimmed with percolated verve. Catra knew she was starting to lose steam as well, but she'd already promised herself another hour before making eyes in her partner's direction and seeing if they were amicable to sneaking off.

"Tired yet, princess?"

"Nope, not at all." Adora's mouth creaked open, letting loose a well-restrained yawn. "Okay, maybe a little. But I don't want to sleep at all. I just want to stay awake forever and soak it all in."

Catra glanced around again, noting for the first time during this bustling day of cake and first dances and "I do's" how much this place she knew like the back of her hand had transformed overnight. For all she cared, it had been some magic trick that old pirate wannabe pulled out of his tricorn hat; still, she couldn't help but appreciate it for the way it made Adora look every ounce the goddess they were, this place a royal court built in their honor, devoted to their worship and undying beatification.

"It is pretty amazing, isn't it?" she snickered after fixing her sights on a particularly artful sunflower arrangement across the way. "Gotta give Seahawk some credit, this old place sure cleans up nice."

Adora nodded. "He told me it was the first wedding he's ever had here. Can you believe it?"

"At a classy joint like this? A place that hosts something called 'Anything But a Cup Night" *every single wee* k? You'd have had me fooled."

After chuckling at the bald sarcasm, Adora breathed out a contented sigh and placed their sword between them.

"It's perfect, anyway. And so are you - perfect in every way."

"You know I'm not," Catra pushed back, matter-of-factly. "And besides, you're biased."

"Maybe I am. But that doesn't change how objectively perfect you are. You're passionate and determined and honest and did I mention that you look incredibly handsome in that suit? DT was right, the pinstripes really suit you."

Catra's eye roll was only natural. Didn't matter who said it, didn't matter if the sentiment made her glow with giddy warmth inside, like the first time she heard Adora say those three small words - she'd never learned to properly take a compliment and she wasn't about to learn on her wedding day.

"Thanks, you only mentioned it about 30,000 times before we even left the bridal shop." She raised a manicured finger, readying to read down an invisible list. "But you forgot ‘jealous,’ ‘hot-headed,’ and ‘a total loner if left to my own devices'. Come to think of it, I think I want that on my headstone. I guess we should figure that out now that you've got me 'til death do us part' or whatever."

At once, Adora's mood soured. "Catra, no! I would never say that. Not in a million years, I would never..."

"Calm down, princess, I didn't say you would."

Catra fiddled idly with one of her vest buttons, a brassy gold set inlaid with a half-eclipsed moon - another of DT's curated picks.

"But if we're trying to sum me up for your personal Yelp review, those would be way more honest descriptors. Hell, I think Glimmer was ready to cut my hair off with how much of a fuss I put up while she brushed it. Why'd you make her a maid-of-honor, anyway? Her and Tech Boy are already married."

Pausing, Adora pursed their lips in thought, the prior offense swiftly fading.

"That's not a bad idea, actually."

"What is?"

"Your hair, short." Adora momentarily pulled back a few of their bangs and made an enthusiastic snipping gesture with their free hand. "I've always been curious about how that'd look on you. It'd make you that much more handsome and you wouldn't have to worry about brushing it out all the time. Plus, then everyone could see more of your cute ears."

Sensing the sudden, involuntary burst of crimson in her cheeks, Catra's hands bolted up to her finely-groomed mane, covering her ears further after they'd already snapped flat to her head in embarrassment. Her knee-jerk snarl, on the other hand, would have given a grizzly bear something to think about.

"Shut up! I am *not* cute!"

Her sharp insistence was met only with laughter as Adora doubled over and wiped a joyful tear from their eye, their heart warming (not for the first time that day) at the prospect of getting to hear that torrid tune every day for the rest of their life.

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Both heads turned with a snap, Adora still grinning like a fool and Catra, scowling like she'd been forced to sit through another three hours of hair and makeup. Looking back through the viewfinder, Bow simply raised an affirmative thumbs up, nodding as he wound the film for another set of candids.

"That's perfect! Keep it up! More of that!"

"I'm about to give you more of my claws if you don't quit it!"

Catra was almost halfway out of her seat, sleeves already rolled up when Adora's hand caught the back of her vest. With a firm tug, they pulled their new wife back, adamant that starting a fight

at their own wedding was not the reason they wanted folks to remember the night.

"Alright, alright." Catra waved off her spouse's firm grip after staring down their impromptu cameraman for a tense moment more. "But I swear, if he takes another goddamn picture, I'm going to smash his stupid little vintage camera over the nearest brick wall."

After shooting an encore set of "I've got my eyes on you" daggers Bow's way, Catra settled back in and tried her best to forget he was there. If she'd had her way, they'd have left hours ago, basically the minute after Netossa had said "you may now kiss." But she'd been warned that such a move, even if it came on the tails of an extremely impressive bridal carry, would not be "polite." So they remained after the ceremony, visiting with their many guests and shoving cake into each other's faces when the moment was right. All in all, it was alright, Catra supposed; a pretty good outcome for something that started out as the most ill-advised crush of her entire feckless life.

Looking back across the table, Catra pushed a pout her partner's way.

"Ugh, I'm just so tired of all these pictures. First, it was the engagement photos, then the pre-ceremony photos, then the *post* -ceremony photos, and now... *this* . Why do we have to take so many freaking pictures, anyway? You already have a million of us at home."

It was true and Adora wasn't going to deny it. Photos from their childhood, photos from those first heady days as an official couple, photos from their senior prom, hands clasped so tight they thought they'd never come unwound - they all hung around their modest little apartment, some in frames and others clipped to long strands of red thread above their bed, all of them overflowing with the kind of tender nostalgia that only years of careful glances and thoughtful words and enthusiastic "yes's" could forge.

Adora tilted their head slightly and traced an idle finger over the table's chippy surface.

"Well, we don't want to ever forget what today felt like, right? It's supposed to be the happiest day of our life, so I wanted to be sure we had plenty of keepsakes from the day."

Catra slapped a hand to her face to choke off a reflexive snort, much to Adora's dismay.

"Wait...is this not...are you not...but we took all that time to plan this. We spent all that time choosing flowers and cake tasting and you said you were okay with the accent colors and..."

"I didn't say I'm not enjoying this," Catra corrected, quickly appraising the disquieting look in her opposite's indelible eyes. "This whole day's been something out of a fairytale, I swear. It's just...I don't want this to be the happiest day of my life."

The truth of the matter did little to clear the dark clouds from Adora's eyes, so Catra went on, lacing their fingers together deftly as she spoke.

"I want things to get better after today. I want this to just be the start. I want to wake up every morning and turn over and find you there because if you are, I know that day will be better than the day before. I know it won't be all milk and honey or whatever - knowing me, I'll find something stupid to fight about before we even get home."

She squeezes Adora's hand that much tighter, the day's festivities melting away like a dream around them.

"But still, I know that even if we fight, even if times are tough, I'll be able to get through it with you. After all of that dust has settled, I know I'll be happier then than I am now because I'll have faced it all with you."

The ceremony itself had been enough to start the waterworks down Adora's cheeks, each teardrop its own felicitous waterfall

that she no longer cared to hide. And now again, with the rings in place and their hands woven tight again, fresh tears made their way over the threshold and dropped silently to the table's surface below. Adora tried her hardest to choke back a new flood, grinning through each wave as she'd practiced so many times before.

"I can't believe it."

Catra's ears perked up in response, perturbed and unsettled. Between them, a few rays of starlight played off their sword's peerless blade.

"What're you talking about? You said basically the same flowery crap a couple of hours ago."

"That's what I mean," Adora nodded, batting away another errant teardrop. "You had that in you all along and you *still* didn't write any vows?"

Catra simply shrugged. "Yeah, that's because vows are for cheesy dorks like you. They're always like 'I promise to always trust you' or 'I promise to always be your rock' or 'I promise to always be grateful for you, even when you burn down our boat for the fourth time.'"

"I think that one was exclusive to Seahawk and Mermista's wedding."

"Whatever, you get my point. Your vows were sweet and heartfelt and I'm never going to stop thinking about that goofy grin you had while you read them. But that all isn't for me. They're just freaking words if I say them. I'd rather show you how much I love you, in any way I can, every single day."

"So." Catra leaned forward just a touch, her elbow now planted firmly on the table and their interwoven hands raised almost to her lips. "No more vows, no more pledges, no more extra fluffy we'll forget about as soon as today is over. Just waking up to this dumb mug every day until we turn to dust. Sound good to you?"

They didn't even need to ponder it. To that, Adora would have said "I will" and "I do" a million times over. Still, their voice quivered ever so slightly, something uneasy lingering in its gossamer strands, and Catra couldn't pretend she wasn't seeing her love's continued tears anymore.

"Hey, why all the crying? I knew you were a big softie but this just seems excessive. You're supposed to be happy today, remember?"

The gentle ribbing was enough to elicit a small, gentle laugh on Adora's part. They held their smile and looked down at the sword, turning it pensively in hand until the inscription of their names above the hilt was visible.

"I am. I am happy, so incredibly happy. I'm just overwhelmed, that's all. I just keep thinking about how beautiful today has been and how excited everyone is for us and how my life would be so different if I hadn't decided to buck up the courage and talk to that bored-looking girl sitting on this bench an eternity ago."

Catra raised an eyebrow at the thought. Eternity ago as it was, she still replayed that cloudless afternoon in her head on her darkest days. Somehow, someway, that sunshine kid always found a way to cut through her malaise, one slurp of saccharin milkshake and unbridled giggle at a time.

"Well, for starters, you'd probably still have those dumb white sneakers I ruined. And I'd definitely have gotten kicked out of school. Wouldn't have had the class president there to bail me out, after all."

"Maybe so," Adora sighed, nostalgia mixing in with the crisp evening air as they exhaled. "But you know what? I think I got something better in exchange for losing those shoes."

"And what's that?" Catra cooed expectantly.

"My best friend. My partner in crime. The love of my life. You."

Adora took the lead again in this stationary waltz, pulling Catra forward such that she was arched over the table, a million glowing lights flickering behind her and in the endless, wine-dark skies above. Pressing their foreheads together, they relished the sound of their partner's purr, sultry and healing and theirs to savor forevermore.

"I love you so much. Don't ever change."

"Wasn't planning on it, princess."

And then, for not the last time that night, their lips met in a gentle kiss, a tender kiss, a loving caress alive with all the same fire and passion that had sparked their fluttering hearts years and years ago. But now, as their thoughts swam in the sea of each other's ambrosial breath, that fire had found a hearth, a place to call home, soothing and stable and prepared to share its warmth as a home was built in its midst. Even as Adora pulled back, that glow lingered on their citrine lips, an amiable reminder of the many ways this woman before her - this celestial flame of a girl - had become her home.

Bow's camera clicked behind them, but neither of them paid it any mind. This night, this moment, was theirs and theirs alone. Finally, *finally* , spring had made its way back into their lives and already, winter felt like a bad dream fading fast. Adora breathed it all in, awe filling their lungs as they met Catra's mismatched eyes anew. What else could they say but...?

"Wow."

Catra sneered and stuck out her tongue before leaning back in for more.

"Don't ruin it, dummy."

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Chapter End Notes

Is that a reference to the OG Heart Pt. 2 script? Perhaps, perhaps 😌 those two dorks were at their absolute dorkiest in that version, I just had to give that treatment a little light in a fic.

But that aside, thank you so so soooo much for reading this whole fic and for bearing with me while I unintentionally slow-walked its rollout. This was such a fun story to piece together and it wouldn't have been possible without EmileeDoodles' stunning artwork allllll the way back in the halcyon days of September. What's that? You don't already follow her? Well for pete's sake, get on that! Your spop-loving heart will thank you.

End Notes

Look at those two! Friends after one afternoon, already sharing a milkshake. I'm sure nothing at all is going to complicate this friendship at allllllllll 😣

Anyway, thanks for reading! This one's been fun to prep because new little details and ingredients found their way into the soup on each pass. It's been simmering all month, too, so I'm hoping the final flavor comes out just right (and by flavor, I mean "sweet" because I promise, these two will get a happy ending!)

Speaking of which, more chapters are on the way! I'm planning 2-3 more as of now and I'm excited to share them in the coming weeks (knock on wood because I should never commit to timelines for releases).

I've got a bunch more SPOP and ToH fics that I'd love for you to read and enjoy, as well. You can come shout at me on Tumblr and Twitter. I'm currently accepting complaints about: "2006 feels like forever ago", "the fact that the table isn't red in the original art", and "how can dark chocolate be anyone's favorite milkshake flavor, seriously, what's wrong with you"

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!